WITNESS TO WAR

MASTER WACE

ANGLO-NORMAN CHRONICLER (C.1115 – C.1183)

NORMAN INVASION OF ENGLAND

"… but I have heard my father say—I remember it well, although I was but a lad—that there were ***seven hundred ships, less four,*** *when they sailed from St. Valéry; and that there were besides these ships,* ***boats and skiffs*** *for the purpose of carrying the* ***arms and harness****. I have found it written (but I know not whether it be true) that there were in all three thousand vessels bearing sails and masts. Any one will know that there must have been a great many men to have furnished out such vessels …The duke placed* ***a lantern on the mast of his ship****, that the other ships might see it, and hold their course after it."*

northward. When a southerly wind finally set in that could carry the Norman fleet to England, coastal defences were almost nonexistent.

Soldiers and horses boarded the ships on September 27—probably ten horses to each transport—and at high tide around 3:00 p.m. they rowed out to an assembly point at sea. There, sails were raised and the fleet set off with the duke's ship in the lead. When night fell, there was no moon, so lanterns were hoisted to keep the ships in formation. A few became detached, but the main body came ashore—unopposed—on the pebble beach at Pevensey on the morning of September 28. Such ships as Harold had on duty were stationed in the Solent, far to the west.

William went on to defeat Harold at Hastings and replace him on the English throne, an event that radically altered the structure of English society and England's relation to mainland Europe.

NORMAN CONQUEST



NORMAN INVASION OF ENGLAND

Date	September 28, 1066
Location	Pevensey, southern England
Result	Norman victory

COMBATANTS

NORMANS	ANGLO-SAXONS

COMMANDERS

William Duke of Normandy	King Harold II of England

FORCES

Ships: c.600–700	**Ships:** c.200

LOSSES

Men: none **Ships:** none	**Men:** none **Ships:** none



KING JOHN'S WAR WITH FRANCE

DAMME



Date May 30–31,1213
Forces English: c.500 ships; French: c.1,700 ships
Losses English: none; French: c.400 ships

Location Scheldt estuary, Flanders

In 1213 French King Philip Augustus was threatening an invasion of England. He assembled a large fleet at the mouth of the Seine, but when English King John made a number of concessions that undermined the justification for an invasion, Philip instead turned his forces against England's ally, the Count of Flanders. The French fleet sailed to the area of the Scheldt estuary known as the Zwyn and came ashore at Damme, threatening the important Flemish cities of Bruges and Ghent.

King John assembled his own fleet, under the command of William de Longespee. It comprised some 500 ships carrying 700 knights and large numbers of mercenaries. Whether the plan was for a preemptive strike to prevent a French invasion is not clear. Leaving England on May 28, the ships reached the Zwyn two days later. The French were totally unprepared for an attack from the sea. Hundreds of their ships lay at anchor or beached on mudflats outside the port, with few men aboard. The English seized these vessels almost without a fight, taking 300 as prizes and burning a hundred more.

The following day de Longespee attacked the port of Damme itself. The fighting moved onto land and there was some sharp combat as the French organized a counterattack. The English force had to reembark in some haste, but sailed happily back to England with its prizes and a wealth of booty.

c.1176–1226

WILLIAM DE LONGESPEE

ENGLISH NOBLEMAN AND MILITARY COMMANDER

An illegitimate son of King Henry II, de Longespee, Third Earl of Salisbury, was also known as William Longsword. Holding the post of warden of the Cinque Ports may have given him some knowledge of naval affairs, but he commanded the English fleet at Damme in 1213 as a leader of fighting men, not as a sailor. He subsequently fought the French on land at the battle of Bouvines in 1214 and later in Gascony. In 1225 he was shipwrecked in the Bay of Biscay while en route to England. He eventually reached home but died shortly after, possibly poisoned by the victor of the battle of Dover, Hubert de Burgh.



FRENCH INVASION OF ENGLAND

DOVER



Date August 24, 1217
Forces English: c.40 ships; French: c.80 ships
Losses English: none; French: 65 ships

Location English Channel, off Dover

The barons' revolt against King John enabled the French to invade England in 1215 and occupy a large part of the country. After John's death in 1216, they wanted to install the Dauphin Louis on the throne of England in place of the nine-year-old Henry III. William Marshal and Hubert de Burgh led the resistance to the French and tried to prevent reinforcements and supplies reaching England from France.

In summer 1217 Marshal and de Burgh were besieged in Dover. On August 24, 70 French supply vessels approached the coast escorted by 10 warships under the command of Eustace the Monk, a famed sea warrior from Boulogne. De Burgh reacted swiftly, setting sail with some 40 ships. At first the English sailed past the incoming convoy, but then came about to attack from the rear and grappled the enemy ships for boarding. They captured almost all the French vessels and towed them into Dover. Eustace was found hiding in the bilges of his ship and summarily executed.

This defeat forced the French to abandon their invasion of England. The battle can probably be counted as the first fought between sailing ships in open sea.



Arms of the Cinque Ports
The Cinque Ports were Dover and four other nearby ports, entrusted with defending England from invasion.